

Communicating by Catcalling: Power Dynamics and Communicative Motivations in Street Harassment

Violence Against Women

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Abstract

To understand the frequencies and communicative motivations of men engaging in street harassment, men's tolerance of sexual harassment, and the relationship between power and street harassment experiences for both men and women using the frameworks of dyadic power theory and feminist theories, we surveyed 348 undergraduate participants at a university in the Pacific United States. Results indicated that men who believe they have lower power than women were the most likely to report engaging in street harassment. Results also indicated a positive relationship between men's reported tolerance for sexual harassment and men's reports of engaging in street harassment.

Keywords

street harassment, power, dyadic power theory, sexual harassment, feminist theory

The growing awareness of street harassment has made it a substantive cultural issue (Kearl, 2014). For example, a video showing a woman silently walking through New York City while getting street harassed more than 100 times in the course of 10 hours went viral and was viewed more than 36 million times in 1 month, suggesting that people are becoming more interested and aware of street harassment as a phenomenon (Hollaback, 2019). Street harassment is generally defined as experiencing unwanted

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sexual attention from strangers in public contexts (Wesselmann & Kelly, 2010). Street harassment can include behaviors such as a stranger telling a woman to “smile,” graphic sexual comments about a woman’s appearance, stalking, groping, and even sexual assault. Street harassment is an international problem; studies of street harassment worldwide find that at least 65% (but sometimes up to 90%) of people surveyed reported encountering some form of street harassment throughout their lifetime (Centre for Equity and Inclusion, 2009; Egyptian Centre for Women’s Rights, 2013; Kearl, 2014; Osmond, 2013). In addition, numerous studies have shown that similar to sexual harassment, street harassment has significant negative effects on victims’ lives (DelGreco & Christensen, 2020; Fairchild & Rudman, 2008; Kearl, 2014).

Many scholars and organizations have argued that street harassment and sexual harassment are ways for men to demonstrate power (Chaudoir & Quinn, 2010; Davis, 1993; di Leonardo, 1981; Hollaback, 2019; Houston, 1988; Tuerkheimer, 1997). What has yet to be studied are the range of motivations that underlie men’s street harassment of women and the role of power in such interactions. Street harassment falls under the umbrella of sexual harassment, but while sexual harassment has been reasonably researched, street harassment literature is limited (Fairchild & Rudman, 2008; Kearl, 2014; Swim & Hyers, 1999). The present study aims to examine power and communicative motivations (i.e., the reasons that drive such behavior) for engaging in street harassment using the frameworks of feminist theories and dyadic power theory. Whereas previous studies on street harassment have generally only examined women’s experiences as victims of street harassment, this study is unique in investigating both men’s experiences as perpetrators and women’s experiences of victimization. Thus, the goal of the study is to understand how men’s perceptions of power and control predict their street harassment behavior, and how women’s perceptions influence their response to such behavior.

Street Harassment

Street harassment is a component of sexual harassment, which is legally defined as unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature (U. S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, 2019). Psychologically, it is more broadly defined as any form of unwanted sexual attention (Ilies et al., 2003; McMaster et al., 2002). By definition, all street harassment is not desired and it attempts to sexualize the receiver and make her feel uncomfortable. In other words, street harassment is unwanted sexual attention.

Within the United States, a study of 2,000 nationally represented individuals found that 65% of women and 25% of men reported being street harassed at least once in their lives, with the majority noting that it happened more than once in their lifetime and was committed by a variety of people (Kearl, 2014). Although street harassment affects all genders, the present study focuses on the context of men harassing women, given that women are the recipients of the majority of street harassment experiences and men are generally the initiators of such behavior (Kearl, 2014). Women are more likely than men to say that they experienced street harassment “sometimes, often, or

daily,” and the majority of both women and men who were street harassed said that men were overwhelmingly the perpetrators of street harassment (Kearl, 2014).

Street harassment negatively impacts women’s lives (Kearl, 2014; Macmillan et al., 2000). Studies have found that women who experience street harassment feel unsafe, experience higher rates of depression and anxiety, have a higher fear of sexual assault, change their lives in some way such as constantly assessing their surroundings or going places in a group instead of alone, are not likely to actively respond to the perpetrator, experience higher self-objectification, experience greater negative intergroup emotions toward men, and have a desire for justice for the perpetrator (Chaudoir & Quinn, 2010; Davis, 1993; DelGreco & Christensen, 2020; Fairchild & Rudman, 2008; Fileborn & Vera-Gray, 2017; Kearl, 2014; Macmillan et al., 2000; Swim & Hyers, 1999). Such behavioral change suggests that male street harassers may be attempting to control women’s behavior through their harassing behavior (e.g., by making women feel unsafe). In other words, underlying street harassment may be issues of power.

Although there have been numerous studies on victims’ experiences of street harassment, to the authors’ knowledge, there are no studies that have empirically measured frequencies of men engaging in street harassment behaviors. Therefore, the following research question is posed:

Research question 1 (RQ1): To what extent do men report engaging in street harassment behaviors toward women?

Previous research suggested that a form of street harassment called “girl watching,” where men objectify women with their gaze, is rooted in power because their gaze demonstrates their right as men to sexually evaluate women, reducing women to sexual objects (Quinn, 2002). However, Quinn (2002) found that men were not consciously motivated by power to street harass women; instead, street harassment was seen as a game played by men *for* men and that the woman’s participation or awareness was not important. Such a finding echoes work on men and masculinity, which suggests that masculinity is a “homosocial” experience, which is often performed for other men (Bird, 1996; Flood, 2008; Kiesling, 2005). The study also points to the complexity of power, in that a behavior can be rooted in the power of the person implementing the behavior without that person being consciously motivated by their power. Thus, the present study builds upon the previous scholarship on men’s reasons for engaging in harassment by empirically testing the motivations of men who street harass women and the connection between such behaviors and perceptions of power.

Power

Power has long been difficult to conceptualize and there are different definitions and terms that often depend on the field in which it is being discussed (Dunbar, 2015; Olson & Rabunsky, 1972; Safilios-Rothschild, 1970; Turk & Bell, 1972). There is agreement among interpersonal communication scholars that power generally refers to the capacity to produce intended effects, and in particular, the ability to influence the

behavior of another person (Dunbar, 2015). This definition also demonstrates that an individual need not be consciously motivated by power to engage in a behavior rooted in power, echoing the findings of Quinn (2002).

Whereas power is generally considered a latent ability that is not always exercised (Dunbar, 2004, 2015), dominance refers to behaviors that are necessarily noticeable such as when one person asserts control and is met by acquiescence from another (Dunbar, 2015). The distinction here is that power is not always accepted or acted on, but dominance is a specific behavior aimed to control another person. Multidimensional definitions of power also acknowledge different types of power that arise from varying bases or sources (French & Raven, 1959). For example, an individual may exercise coercive power, which is power based on the threat of punishment; reward power, which is power based on the promise of monetary or nonmonetary compensation; legitimate power, which is power based on a person's right to influence; expert power, which is power based on a person's superior knowledge; or referent power, which is power based on the target's identification with an influencing agent. Thus, power can emerge from a number of sources and be implemented in a number of ways.

Power can also be a process. Similar to French and Raven (1959), Cromwell and Olsen (1975) note that power can have difference bases, but they also acknowledge that power can emerge through different processes and produce varying outcomes. Power processes refer to the interactional techniques that individuals use to gain control, and can include behaviors such as control attempts, assertiveness, negotiation, persuasion, influence, and other direct or indirect acts that may modify the decision-making process (Cromwell & Olsen, 1975). Power outcomes refer to the question of who makes the final decision, who ultimately possesses control, or who "wins" (Cromwell & Olsen, 1975). These many approaches to understanding power demonstrate the complex nature of this concept and the importance of employing a clear theoretical framework to help understand power in the context of street harassment.

Dyadic Power Theory

Dyadic power theory (Dunbar, 2004) focuses on dyadic interactions and the negotiation of power between the receiver and initiator, thus making the theory relevant to the context of street harassment. Although the theory has typically been used in contexts where there is an established relationship, it has also been employed in studies with stranger interactions (Dunbar & Abra, 2010). In addition, the theorist notes that the influence of power on satisfaction with a particular interaction should not be confined to the context of marriage, as it is present in every interaction, "even one with a total stranger" (Dunbar & Abra, 2010, p. 664). In other words, understanding power in social interactions, even those that may be brief or occur between strangers, is important because it can contribute to satisfaction with specific interactions that occur throughout a given day.

Dyadic power theory defines power as based on the level of authority and resources people have. Authority refers to norms regarding who "ought to" control different situations (Dunbar, 2004). Resources are anything that one interaction partner may make

available to the other partner to help the other partner satisfy their own needs or attain goals. Power, authority, and resources are all relative, meaning that they are perceptions of one's own capacity in relation to another person; they are not absolute (Dunbar, 2004; Rollins & Bahr, 1976). As such, power incorporates the perspectives of both individuals in the interaction (Dunbar, 2004).

Dyadic power theory proposes that the relationship between perceived power and control attempts (i.e., attempting to change the behavior of another) is curvilinear, such that individuals who perceive their power as extremely high or low compared with their interaction partner will make fewer control attempts, and individuals who perceive their power as equal will make more control attempts (Dunbar, 2004). If the initiator is perceived by the receiver as having lower relative power, then a counter control attempt is likely to be made by the receiver, which would reduce the effectiveness of the original control attempt by lessening the probability of the initiator succeeding in gaining control. A counter control attempt is an attempt made by the receiver of the control attempt to gain control of the situation, which is inconsistent with the control attempt of the initiator.

Most of the literature supports the theory's claim about relatively equal power interaction partners utilizing control attempts, but empirical evidence does not support the idea that people who are relatively high in power are less likely to make control attempts. Dunbar and colleagues (Dunbar & Abra, 2010; Dunbar et al., 2008; Dunbar & Johnson, 2015) found that individuals who were perceived as equal in relative power compared with their interaction partners displayed more dominance than individuals who had lower relative power, followed by individuals who were higher in relative power. Research on married couples further finds that the relationship between power and dominance is largely linear (Dunbar & Burgoon, 2005).

Because sexual harassment is often rooted in attempts to control behavior (Schultz, 1998), it is likely that street harassment, which shares many similarities to sexual harassment (DeGrecio & Christensen, 2020; Fairchild & Rudman, 2008; Kearl, 2014), can also be considered a control attempt. For example, guided by the tenets of dyadic power theory, a man who feels powerful should not need to street harass a woman as a way to obtain power because he already has it. However, if a man feels that he is equal in power to a woman on the street and would like to obtain more power, he would be more likely to street harass. Even if the initiator does not consciously realize that power is involved, if he wants the receiver to change her behavior in any way as a result of the street harassment, then the act of street harassment is a control attempt. If the initiator does not intend for the receiver to change her behavior in any way, then the street harassment would not be considered a control attempt. Thus, it is possible that men may vary in the extent to which they view street harassment as a control attempt; therefore, the following research question is posed:

Research Question 2 (RQ 2): To what extent do men report using street harassment as a control attempt?

Dyadic power theory also suggests that when the receiver of a control attempt perceives the initiator as relatively equal or lower in power to themselves, the receiver would likely make a counter control attempt against the initiator. A counter control attempt would be any behavior that directly goes in opposition to the control attempt, such as being told to smile and scowling instead. In the context of a man street harassing a woman he does not know in a public setting, if the woman perceives herself as having relatively equal power to the man, she should be more likely to make a counter control attempt. Thus, the following is predicted:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Women who believe they are equal in power to men in general communication situations will be more likely to use counter control attempts in situations of street harassment compared with women who believe they have lower power than men.

Feminist Theories

Feminist and gender scholars often discuss power in terms of men and women, where men almost universally have more power than women based on their roles and status in society. For example, feminist theories assume that members of groups defined by sex, race, and other factors occupy distinct positions in society, and that women comprise a subordinate group because they did not participate in the original defining of that society (Wood, 2014). As such, feminist theories have been used to understand power dynamics within street harassment interactions (Davis, 1993; di Leonardo, 1981). Proponents of feminist theories have argued that street harassment directed toward women is a form of demonstrating power by men, as it is typically imposed on women by men due to a status threat and has negative effects on women (Davis, 1993; di Leonardo, 1981; Tuerkheimer, 1997). For example, di Leonardo (1981) contended that men are threatened by a perceived lack of power and status as a result of the feminist movement and women moving into the public sphere, so they street harass women as a form of retaliation and to let women know that the public sphere is a male space. Thus, unlike the findings of Quinn (2002) which suggest that men may not be consciously engaging in street harassing behaviors as a means of exerting power over women, this line of theorizing suggests that men street harass strategically as a means of actively demonstrating power over women. Davis (1993) similarly acknowledged the power dynamics of street harassment incidents, pointing out that street harassment gives men the power to make women hate themselves or their body and causes women to restrict their mobility to avoid it. Davis (1993) also said that women link street harassment with the possibility of being raped, which in itself is a violent act of power.

Power may also be connected to men's perceptions that such behavior is innocent and harmless. For example, Tuerkheimer (1997) argued that because of the power structure between men and women, women suffer in ways that men do not, so when men say they do not think street harassment is harmful, it comes from a place of power and does not recognize that women are oppressed based on gender while men are not.

Houston (1988) commented on some general responses by men who are confronted about street harassing women, such as "I do not think it harms anybody." Houston (1988) debunked that response by claiming that the reason men do not view street harassment as harmful to them is because of their power and status.

These varying conceptualizations of the role of power in street harassment as both conscious and subconscious reinforce the complexity of understanding power in social interactions. Indeed, many feminist scholars' and organizations' definitions of street harassment involve indirect allusions to power dynamics, such as objectifying behavior, whereas others include an outright acknowledgment of power dynamics (Chaudoir & Quinn, 2010; di Leonardo, 1981; Hollaback, 2019). Hollaback (2019), an organization dedicated to spreading awareness of street harassment by collecting stories, pictures, and videos of street harassment globally and sharing them online, defined street harassment as "a power dynamic that constantly reminds historically subordinated groups of their vulnerability to assault in public spaces. Furthermore, it reinforces the ubiquitous sexual objectification of these groups in everyday life" (About section, What is Street Harassment?).

One of the obstacles to studying power in street harassment interactions is that the theories and methodology used to understand power in previous studies often involved a baseline pre-existing relationship, such as a marriage or romantic relationship (Dunbar, 2004, 2015). There have been very few studies that measured perceived power dynamics in stranger relationships and how these perceptions may influence interpersonal behaviors, despite its clear relevance to the context of street harassment. For example, in one study, dyadic power theory was tested using stranger relationships where participants were instructed to work together with a confederate having varying levels of power to rank-order 12 items for their survival value (Dunbar & Abra, 2010). The results indicated that participants in the equal power condition used more control attempts than participants in the lower power condition, but there was no significant difference between amount of control attempts in equal and higher power conditions, which does not fully support the curvilinear relationship proposed by dyadic power theory (Dunbar & Abra, 2010). Although this study used participants who had not met previously, they were still required to interact for approximately 20 min and had to work together to accomplish a goal that had a monetary incentive, which is markedly different from a street harassment context where strangers are unlikely to need to work together for extended periods of time.

In addition, although Dunbar and Abra (2010) studied stranger interactions, the scale to measure power was still based on more long-term interactions that would not apply in street harassment interactions (e.g., "Who made most of the decisions about how to rank items?" "Who influenced the decisions of the other person more?" "Who could more easily persuade the other to change their mind?"). Given that street harassment typically occurs in public spaces with strangers who are unlikely to spend more than a few moments together or interact again, there has not yet been a clear theoretical framework or measure to adequately detect the ways in which power is involved in this behavior. Given this unique context, in addition to the different perspectives offered by dyadic power theory and feminist theories when it comes to the relationship

between street harassment and power, two possibilities exist regarding the association between street harassment and power.

First, following the principles of dyadic power theory, if the man felt that he had extremely high or low power compared with the woman, he would be unlikely to use street harassment as a control attempt because either his high power status speaks for itself or his power status is too low for a control attempt to make a difference (Dunbar, 2004). However, a second possibility, as suggested by feminist scholars, is that men universally have more power than women due to their societal status and roles, but when they feel threatened by a perceived lack of power, they lash out, such as by street harassing women (Davis, 1993; di Leonardo, 1981; Laniya, 2005; Thompson, 1994). The empirical evidence currently does not strongly support the idea that people who have extremely high relative power do not use control attempts, but it does indicate that people who are relatively equal in power are most likely to use control attempts with colleagues (Dunbar & Abra, 2010; Dunbar & Burgoon, 2005; Dunbar et al., 2008; Dunbar & Johnson, 2015). A critical test of the relationship between power and street harassment behaviors could clarify the relationship and answer the question of whether the relationship is curvilinear (as dyadic power theory predicts) or linear (as feminist scholars predict). Thus, the following competing hypotheses are put forth:

Hypothesis 2a (H2a): Men who perceive themselves to be equal in power to women will use more street harassment behaviors on women compared with men who perceive themselves to have higher or lower power than women.

Hypothesis 2b (H2b): Men who perceive themselves to have lower power than women will use more street harassment behaviors on women compared with men who perceive themselves to have equal or higher relative power than women.

Confirming H2a would provide support for dyadic power theory's (Dunbar, 2004) propositions, whereas confirming H2b would provide support for feminist theories.

Communicative Motivations and Tolerance for Sexual Harassment

Although power is argued to be a key component of street harassment, other motivations may also exist. Research on motivations for communicating indicate that people communicate with one another for a number of reasons including pleasure (e.g., it's fun), affection (e.g., to help others), inclusion (e.g., to feel less lonely), escape (e.g., there is nothing better to do), relaxation (e.g., to feel less tense), and control (e.g., to get someone to do something) (Rubin et al., 1988). With the exception of one qualitative study (i.e., Quinn, 2002), scholars have previously only offered conjecture on why they believe men would street harass women and have not empirically investigated the cause. Even when men are asked about why they engage in street harassment behaviors, results indicate that the motivations are more complex than generally thought (Quinn, 2002). Currently, it is not known how power or other motivations manifest in specific street harassment behaviors. For example, it is possible that some men are not considering power, but rather, are bored or believe they are expressing a compliment

or affection. It is important to investigate the communicative motives (i.e., what the initiator wants or expects out of the interaction) underlying street harassment to fully understand the range of reasons men may partake in such behavior. Thus, the following research question is posed:

Research question 3 (RQ3): What are various communicative motivations that street harassers report?

Obviously, not all men support or partake in such behavior. Men's aptitude for engaging in street harassment may vary in accordance with their own feelings toward sexual harassment. Research suggests that men are more likely to have a higher tolerance of sexual harassment when they have strong beliefs about traditional gender roles (Swim & Cohen, 1997), are high in social dominance (Pratto et al., 1994; Pryor, 1987), are high in masculinity (Powell, 1986; Pryor, 1987), have hostile attitudes toward women (Pryor et al., 1995; Pryor & Whalen, 1997), and have hostile and/or benevolently sexist attitudes (Glick & Fiske, 1997). Because street harassment behavior is a component of more general sexual harassment (and men's likelihood of engaging in sexual harassment is positively correlated with likelihood of engaging in street harassment; Wesselmann & Kelly, 2010), it would follow that men's tolerance of sexual harassment will be positively related to reports of engaging in street harassment behaviors. In other words, men who are generally more accepting of sexually harassing behavior should be more likely to report engaging in one form of such behavior—street harassment. Thus, the following is predicted as a means of verifying the association between sexual harassment and street harassment noted in previous work:

Hypothesis 3 (H3): The more men report tolerating sexual harassment, the more likely they will be to report engaging in street harassment behaviors.

Method

Participants

Participants were recruited from undergraduate communication courses at a large research university in the Pacific United States. The only requirement was that participants be at least 18 years old to participate. Participants did not need to have experiences of street harassment to participate in the study. Four-hundred and seven undergraduate students participated in the study. Of those, 59 were deleted because they had significant missing data or did not answer any of the items. Therefore, the total number of participants whose data were used in the analyses was 348, which included 143 men (41%) and 205 women (59%). Participants received course credit or extra credit for their involvement in the study.

The average age for male participants was 21.36 years ($SD = 4.37$, range = 18–44) and for female participants, it was 19.99 years ($SD = 1.94$, range = 18–29). Participants identified as Asian (men: $n = 82$, 57%; women: $n = 108$, 53%),

Caucasian (men: $n = 33$, 23%; women: $n = 47$, 23%), Hispanic (men: $n = 4$, 3%; women: $n = 16$, 8%), African American (men: $n = 4$, 3%; women: $n = 0$, 0%), Pacific Islander (men: $n = 15$, 11%; women: $n = 19$, 9%), and Other (men: $n = 5$, 4%; women: $n = 15$, 7%).

Procedure

Two survey forms were used, one for men and one for women. Each survey had slightly different scales to assess men and women's perspectives of street harassment. Undergraduate students signed up for the survey through an online system. After agreeing to participate, the survey began on the following page by asking for demographic information, followed by a section on street harassment behaviors, a section about control attempts and counter control attempts, a section about power and gender, and a section on communicative motives. On the men's survey only, there was an additional section that measured sexual harassment attitudes. Participants had the option to opt out at any point during the survey. When the participants completed or opted out of the survey, they were shown a debriefing speech. Participants were instructed to click on a link to another survey, where they entered their name to receive credit for taking the survey.

Measures

Frequency and desirability of street harassment. Frequency of street harassment behaviors or experiencing street harassment was measured using a list of 28 possible street harassing behaviors from Sullivan (2011), who developed the scale from Lord's (2009) study that pilot tested a briefer version of the scale with eight harassing behaviors. The scale was designed to represent a broad range of street harassment experiences. On the survey given to women, one item was mistakenly left off, resulting in 27 behaviors being on the survey given to women and 28 on the survey given to men. Participants were instructed to think about the past year and think only about individuals they have never met before out in public. Male participants indicated which of the behaviors they engaged in directed at women and how often using 7-point scales (0 = *Never*, 1 = *Once in the past year*, 2 = *A few times in the past year*, 3 = *About once a month*, 4 = *A few times a month*, 5 = *Almost every day*, 6 = *Multiple times a day*; see Table 1). Each behavior was considered separately. An indication of engaging in each behavior was given a score of one (regardless of how often they actually engaged in the behavior over the course of a year), resulting in a possible overall street harassment behavior score of 0–28 points total, with higher scores indicating engaging in a greater range of street harassment behaviors.

Female participants indicated how many of the possible street harassment behaviors they experienced by men using the same 7-point scales. Female participants also indicated which behaviors were wanted or unwanted by the receiver. This measure was used as a check to determine whether the street harassment behavior list was

Table 1. Frequency of Men Engaging in Street Harassment Behaviors.

Street harassment behaviors	Men
	<i>n</i> (%)
Asked a woman for her name	108 (76)
Complimented a woman's appearance	100 (70)
Asked a woman for her phone number	87 (61)
Stared at a woman in a sexual way as you walked past her on the street	72 (50)
Told a woman to smile	71 (50)
Asked a woman if she has a boyfriend or is married	69 (48)
Commented on a woman's weight saying that she is either too fat or too skinny	42 (29)
Made negative comments about a woman's appearance as she walked by	36 (26)
Made gestures and calls for a woman to come over to where you are standing	31 (22)
Slowed down your car so that you can drive beside a woman as she walked and either watched her or spoke to her	29 (20)
Blown kisses or made other romantic gestures to a woman on the street	27 (19)
Told a woman how pretty or attractive she is as she walked down the street and then repeated these comments louder, trying to get her attention	24 (17)
Approached the male person a woman was walking or sitting with and complimented him on her appearance or on his successful conquest of her	24 (17)
Yelled things like "hey sexy!" or "you're fine!" from a car while driving past a woman as she was walking or waiting for someone	23 (16)
Whistled, yelled, or honked at a woman from your car while driving	23 (16)
Walked past and directed sounds at a woman	19 (13)
Yelled comments about a woman's appearance at her while she was jogging	18 (13)
Yelled compliments to a woman about her appearance as she walked past your work site	16 (11)
Walked past a woman and commented on her weight, saying that you approve of her size	16 (11)
Called a woman insulting names as she walked past you	15 (11)
Touched a woman as she walked past you	12 (8)
Made sexual comments to a woman and then followed her as she walked	11 (8)
Aggressively touched a woman as she walked past you	10 (7)
Made sexually explicit gestures to a woman as she walked	9 (6)
Offered a woman money for sex when she is either walking or standing and waiting for someone	9 (6)
Called for a woman's attention and when she ignored you began shouting insults at her	8 (6)
You showed a woman your penis on the street	8 (6)
Pulled your car over as a woman was walking and asked her to do sexually explicit things with you	8 (6)

Note. Frequency percentages greater than .25 are shown in boldface. Percentages were calculated from a sub-sample of 143 men.

indeed composed of behaviors that were unwanted by women (a definitional requirement for street harassment). An overwhelming majority of women indicated that most of the 27 behaviors were unwanted. The few participants that indicated certain behaviors were wanted, typically selected more mild behaviors such as appearance-based compliments.

Control attempts and counter control attempts. Control attempts and counter control attempts were measured as continuous variables, using a list of 18 possible responses to street harassment that the researcher determined, based on past studies of common responses to street harassment (Lord, 2009; Sullivan et al., 2010; Swim & Hyers, 1999, for example, “start a conversation,” “smile,” and “insulting gesture”). Men were asked to indicate which behaviors they would desire as a response to any of the street harassment behaviors. Any behavioral selection other than “no change in behavior” indicated a control attempt because it is not a control attempt if the initiator did not want a change in the receiver’s behavior. Women were asked to think about the most recent time they were street harassed and indicate which behaviors they think the harasser wanted them to do and which behavior they actually did. Any behavioral selection by the female participant other than the behavior that was perceived as what the harasser wanted indicated a counter control attempt. Total counter control attempts were calculated based on the sum of counter control attempts for each of the 18 behaviors. Higher scores indicated engaging in more counter control attempts.

Power. Power was measured using a single item modified from Dunbar and Abra’s (2010) scale. To the authors’ knowledge, there are no scales that measure power within a stranger relationship, only established close relationships. For example, established power scales include items such as “Who makes major household decisions?” (Blood & Wolfe, 1960), “Who would you say is more emotionally involved in the relationship?” (Felmlee, 1994), and “Who influences the other person more?” (Dunbar & Abra, 2010). Other scholars have simply used the item, “Who has more power in your relationship?” (Dunbar & Abra, 2010; Felmlee, 1994). Because the latter question is the most direct way to assess power, and can easily be modified to a stranger context, that is the item that was chosen to measure power in the present study. In addition, there is precedent in the power literature to use a single item (Felmlee, 1994). Therefore, the scale was modified to pertain to general interactions between men and women instead of a specific relationship. As a result, only one item of the four original items was included because it was the only item to address general interactions between men and women and thus was the most relevant to this study.

Participants were asked to assess which gender-based communication partner generally has more power. The item was rated on 3-point scales; for male participants the scale was 1 = *women*, 2 = *both equally*, and 3 = *my gender*, and for female participants the scale was 1 = *men*, 2 = *both equally*, and 3 = *my gender*. The use of the term “my gender” instead of listing the actual gender was chosen as a way to trigger in-group perceptions among participants. Women and men who selected their own gender for the item were classified as higher power. Women and men who selected the other

gender for the item were classified as lower power. Those participants who selected "both equally" for the item were classified as equal power. Women indicated that they had equal power compared with men most frequently ($n = 100, 49\%$), followed by lower power compared with men ($n = 69, 34\%$), and higher power compared with men ($n = 33, 16\%$). Men indicated that they had equal power compared with women most frequently ($n = 79, 55\%$), followed by lower power compared with women ($n = 37, 26\%$) and higher power compared with women ($n = 26, 18\%$).

Communicative motives. Communicative motives were measured using the interpersonal communication motives scale (Rubin et al., 1988). This measure assesses why people communicate with one another. The scale includes a list of 28 possible reasons in six categories for why people would initiate communication with another person. The six categories are pleasure (e.g., because it's fun), affection (e.g., to help others), inclusion (e.g., because it makes me feel less lonely), escape (e.g., because I have nothing better to do), relaxation (e.g., because it makes me feel less tense), and control (e.g., because I want someone to do something for me). Men were asked to indicate the extent to which each motivation best expressed their own reasons for talking to women whom they do not know in public spaces using a 7-point scale from 1 (*Completely disagree*) to 7 (*Completely agree*). Women were asked to indicate the extent to which they agree with the statements about the reasons why men would communicate with women whom they do not know in public spaces using the same 7-point scale. The mean was calculated across the items within each category and higher scores indicated more of that particular reason or motivation. The reliability estimates for each category of motivation ranged from .89 to .97 (see Table 2).

Tolerance of sexual harassment. Men's attitudes about sexual harassment were measured using Mazer and Percival's (1989) scale. There are 19 items in this measure such as "Most women who are sexually insulted by a man provoke his behavior by the way they talk, act, or dress." Men were asked about the extent to which they agree with each item using a 7-point scale from 1 (*Completely disagree*) to 7 (*Completely agree*). Mean scores were calculated and higher scores indicated more acceptance and tolerance of sexual harassment and less agreement with contemporary feminist understandings of its causes. In general, the men neither tolerated nor did not tolerate sexual harassment ($M = 3.50, SD = 1.01$). Reliability of this measure was .88.

Social desirability. Although it was not a key variable of interest, social desirability was measured using a modified 10-item version of the Marlowe–Crowne Social Desirability Scale (Crowne & Marlowe, 1960; Strahan & Gerbasi, 1972) to assess possible social desirability response bias due to the sensitive nature of the topics covered in the survey. Participants read the items in this measure and indicated if each item is true or false. Sample items included "I like to gossip at times (False)" and "I never resent being asked to return a favor (True)." Some items were considered an indication of social desirability if marked true and would get a score of 1 if marked true and 0 if marked false. Others were considered an indication of social desirability if marked

Table 2. Reported Frequencies of Desired or Believed to be Desired Responses to Street Harassment Between Men and Women.

Response	Men	Women
	<i>n</i> (%)	<i>n</i> (%)
Smile	62 (55)	159 (78)
Start a conversation	51 (46)	167 (82)
Make eye contact	40 (36)	152 (74)
Pleasant gesture	36 (32)	137 (67)
Wave	34 (30)	143 (70)
Laugh	30 (27)	94 (46)
Move closer	26 (23)	163 (80)
Say they do not like it	13 (12)	154 (75)
Completely ignore	23 (21)	17 (8)
No change in behavior	18 (16)	31 (15)
Say they do like it	23 (21)	37 (18)
Look visibly upset	6 (5)	51 (25)
Leave the vicinity	8 (7)	30 (15)
Move farther away	7 (6)	20 (10)
Shout something pleasant	7 (6)	128 (62)
Look angry/glare	5 (5)	41 (20)
Insulting gesture	0 (0)	73 (36)
Shout something insulting	1 (1)	67 (33)

Note. Frequency percentages greater than .25 are shown in boldface. Percentages for men were calculated from a sub-sample of 112 men who reported ever engaging in street harassment (SH) behaviors. Percentages for women were calculated from a sub-sample of 205 women.

false and would get a score of 1 if marked false and 0 if marked true. Scores were calculated by assigning 1 point to each item, so results were between 0 and 10 points. Higher points indicated more social desirability bias. In general, both men and women reported below average levels of social desirability bias (men: $M = 3.87$, $SD = 1.66$; women: $M = 4.01$, $SD = 1.77$). Reliability was .38 for men and .46 for women.

Results

Frequency of Street Harassment and Control Attempts

RQ1 asked how often men reported engaging in street harassment behaviors and RQ2 asked how often the men who reported engaging in street harassment behaviors did so as a way to control others' behavior. To answer these research questions, descriptive frequencies were run. Results indicated that 78% ($n = 112$) of the men surveyed reported engaging in street harassment behaviors, calculated by how many participants reported a score of at least one of the possible 28 points in the street harassment

scale. Of those, 87% ($n = 97$) did so with the intent of changing the recipient's behavior in some way. Only 15 men (13%) indicated that they would like no change in behavior to be the response to street harassment. The majority of men indicated that they would like women to respond to street harassment in a more pleasant way such as smiling, waving, and starting a conversation (see Table 2).

To provide additional insight into these research questions, women were also asked to think about the most recent time they were street harassed and indicate which behaviors they think the harasser wanted them to do. Results indicated that women generally reported higher frequencies than men for each of the behaviors that they believed men wanted them to do, including the more unpleasant responses such as looking angry and making an insulting gesture (see Table 2).

Counter Control Attempts

H1 predicted that if a man uses street harassment behaviors as a control attempt on a woman, but the woman believes that she has equal power, the woman is more likely to make a counter control attempt than if she believes she has lower power. To test this hypothesis, a univariate analysis of variance was run with power (equal, high, and low) on use of counter control attempts. Reported use of counter control attempts did not differ between women who believed they had equal power to men ($M = 13.13$, $SD = 4.67$) compared with women who believed they had lower power than men ($M = 13.58$, $SD = 4.35$), $F(2, 198) = .21$, $p = .81$, $\eta^2 = .002$. In other words, the results did not support H1.

Power

H2a and H2b were designed as a critical test to predict differences in street harassment behaviors depending on perceptions of relative power. H2a predicted that men who believe they are equal in power to women will use street harassment more than men who believe they have higher or lower power compared with women. H2b predicted that men who believe they have lower power compared with women will use street harassment more than men who believe they have equal or lower power compared with women. To test these hypotheses, a one-way analysis of variance test was conducted with the factor of power (equal, high, and low) on frequencies of street harassment and an overall significant difference was found: $F(2, 139) = 4.68$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = .06$. To probe this result, a Tukey least significant difference (LSD) post hoc was conducted. Those results indicated that there was a significant difference in street harassment behavior between men who reported believing that they had equal power to women ($M = 2.59$, $SD = 2.59$) and men who reported believing that they had lower power than women ($M = 4.14$, $SD = 2.54$). In addition, the Tukey LSD post hoc did not result in a significant difference between men who reported believing that they had higher power than women ($M = 2.77$, $SD = 2.55$), and men who reported believing that they had equal or lower power than women. Therefore, H2a was not supported but H2b was supported.

Table 3. Communicative Motivations Reported for Street Harassment.

Communicative motivations	Men		Women		t test
	M (SD)	Reliability	M (SD)	Reliability	
Affection	4.51 (1.57)	.92	3.11 (1.66)	.95	-.39***
Pleasure	3.92 (1.67)	.96	4.72 (1.37)	.93	.25***
Inclusion	3.58 (1.63)	.91	3.44 (1.49)	.89	-.04
Escape	3.13 (1.60)	.90	3.75 (1.54)	.89	.19***
Relaxation	3.10 (1.74)	.97	3.23 (1.47)	.94	.04
Control	2.95 (1.68)	.91	3.89 (1.64)	.84	.27***

*** $p < .001$ (one-tailed).

Communicative Motivations

RQ3 asked about the various communicative motivations that street harassers report. To answer this research question, descriptive frequencies were run. Results showed that of the men who reported engaging in street harassment behaviors ($n = 125$), the most frequent motivation reported was affection, followed by pleasure, inclusion, escape, relaxation, and control. Another way of addressing this research question is to examine communicative motivations from the women’s perspective. Female participants were asked to think about the most recent time they were street harassed and to indicate which motivations they believed the harasser had. The most frequent motivations reported by women were pleasure, control, escape, inclusion, relaxation, and affection (see Table 3).

Post hoc analyses indicated that the communication motivations identified by the men and women generally differed significantly from each other, except for two categories of motivations (see Table 3). Men’s reports of affection ($M = 4.51, SD = 1.57$) as a reason to engage in street harassment behaviors were significantly higher than women’s reports of affection ($M = 3.11, SD = 1.66$), $t(348) = -.39, p < .001$. Men’s reports of pleasure ($M = 3.92, SD = 1.67$) as a reason to engage in street harassment behaviors were significantly lower than women’s reports of pleasure ($M = 4.72, SD = 1.37$), $t(348) = .25, p < .001$. Men’s reports of escape ($M = 3.13, SD = 1.60$) as a reason to engage in street harassment behaviors were significantly lower than women’s reports of escape ($M = 3.75, SD = 1.54$), $t(348) = .19, p < .001$. Men’s reports of control ($M = 2.95, SD = 1.68$) as a reason to engage in street harassment behaviors were significantly lower than women’s reports of control ($M = 3.89, SD = 1.64$), $t(348) = .27, p < .001$.

Tolerance of Sexual Harassment

H3 predicted that the more men report tolerating sexual harassment, the more likely they will be to report engaging in street harassment behaviors. To test this hypothesis, a Pearson product–moment correlation was conducted. The results showed there was

a significant association between reported tolerances of sexual harassment and street harassment behavior for men, $r(128) = .19, p < .05$. Therefore, H3 was supported.

Discussion

This study was conducted to better understand the frequencies and communicative motivations of men engaging in street harassment behaviors, men's tolerance of sexual harassment, and the relationship between power and experiences of street harassment for both men and women using the frameworks of dyadic power theory (Dunbar, 2004) and feminist theories. We hypothesized that there would be differences in frequencies of street harassment behaviors by men and counter control attempts by women depending on perceptions of power, and that there would be a positive relationship between men's reported tolerance for sexual harassment and men's reports of engaging in street harassment behaviors.

Implications and Contributions

This study is one of the first of its kind to quantitatively measure frequencies of engaging in street harassment, not just frequencies of experiencing the phenomenon. Results indicated that the vast majority of men surveyed reported engaging in street harassment behaviors. Most men who reported engaging in street harassment behaviors reported more mild behaviors such as complimenting a woman's appearance, leering, or telling a woman to smile, but men also reported engaging in more severe behaviors such as insulting women, following women, and physically assaulting women. There was not a single street harassment behavior that no one reported engaging in, suggesting that this is a pervasive problem that needs to be further addressed. In addition, the majority of men surveyed reported that they wanted the recipient's behavior to change as a result of their street harassment behaviors, suggesting that street harassment is often used as a control attempt by men.

There were no significant differences in counter control attempts for women who believed they either had higher, lower, or equal power compared with men. One possible explanation for this result is that because women indicated that they believed men desired a wider variety of responses to street harassment compared with what men themselves reported desiring, it may be that college women are not always sure of what men want from them when they street harass. Perhaps if women knew what men wanted their reactions to be, it would be easier for women to decide if they wanted to use counter control attempts or not. In addition, since the majority of women respond to street harassment in a passive way, it could be difficult to tease apart whether they are using counter control attempts or simply trying not to engage with the harasser.

Contrary to dyadic power theory (Dunbar, 2004), but in support of feminist theories, results indicated that men who believe they have lower power than women were the most likely to report engaging in street harassment behaviors. Although this result did not support the dyadic power theory hypothesis, the findings indicated that power

is related in some way to the use of street harassment, even if it does not follow the curvilinear relationship outlined by Dunbar (2004). Instead, the findings were consistent with feminist theories that state that men may be threatened by a perceived lack of power and status as a result of the feminist movement, and so they street harass women as a way to try to regain some of that power (as suggested by di Leonardo, 1981). Another explanation could be due to the lack of consequences and relational history that come with stranger interactions. In street harassment situations, there is no relational history or future between the interactants, therefore, the person who believes they have lower power may feel as if they have nothing to lose and may lash out to feel more empowered. The same person who feels powerless would likely not do that in a home or work setting due to the ongoing relational dynamics (Dunbar, 2004). The lack of support for dyadic power theory indicates that the stranger context may be outside the scope of dyadic power theory because of the lack of relational history. Perhaps due to the salient nature of gender in the street harassment context, feminist theories offer a more accurate prediction.

Although the majority of men reported that they used street harassment as a way to change the recipient's behavior, they reported other motivations for engaging in street harassment as well. Results indicated that the most frequent motivation for street harassment as reported by men was affection and the least frequent was control. The results also showed interesting discrepancies between how men and women view street harassment. Men were significantly more likely to report affection, meaning they engaged in the behavior to express care or liking, as the motivation for street harassment than women, which suggests that men may genuinely believe that street harassment is a pleasant experience. Women, on the other hand, most frequently reported pleasure (meaning they believed that men engaged in the behavior because they thought it was fun and it made them happy) and control (meaning they believed men engaged in the behavior because they wanted something from the target of the harassment), as men's perceived motivations for street harassing. In other words, women believe that men enjoy street harassment but they also believe men do it for control reasons such as to feel more powerful or to cause the recipient to change their behavior. These results show that men do use street harassment as a way to change the recipient's behavior, but they do not believe it is a negative experience and do not expect negative reactions from women.

The majority of men also indicated that they would like women to respond to street harassment in a more pleasant way such as smiling, waving, and starting a conversation. Women indicated more often than men that they thought men wanted more unpleasant reactions such as shouting insults and making an insulting gesture as well as pleasant reactions. Such results suggest that college men may view street harassment as a pleasant experience for women and are likely not expecting women to give an angry or unpleasant reaction to being street harassed. This expectation could be explained by the feminine stereotype of women wanting to be complimented on their appearance and the assumption that women will be pleasant in all interactions. Interestingly, power is still a key component in how men expect women to react to street harassment. For example, Hecht and LaFrance (1998) found in a study of power

and smiling that powerful people can smile when they feel like it but low power people do not have the freedom to not smile. The authors noted that having less power is associated with positive expression being disconnected from positive feeling; therefore, people with less power feel required to maintain some positive expression regardless of how positive they feel. The authors concluded that having power gives one the prerogative to behave as one chooses (Hecht & LaFrance, 1998). These results, taken with the results of men expecting positive reactions to street harassment, could explain that because of the general power dynamic between men and women, women feel forced to react to street harassment in a certain way and feel upset by that, while men simply do not understand that need because they feel that they have the freedom to act as they choose. These results are in opposition to some feminist scholars (e.g., di Leonardo, 1981) who have argued that men are aware that women do not like to be street harassed, but they do it anyway to demonstrate their power. Instead, these results suggest that college men may not be aware of the power-laden implications of their behavior and street harass with well-meaning (though still problematic) intentions.

Such findings may also suggest that such men hold benevolently sexist attitudes. Benevolent sexism is defined as

a set of interrelated attitudes toward women that are sexist in terms of viewing women stereotypically and in restricted roles but that are subjectively positive in feeling tone (for the perceiver) and also tend to elicit behaviors typically categorized as prosocial (e.g., helping) or intimacy-seeking (e.g., self-disclosure). (Glick & Fiske, 1996, p. 491)

Studies have shown that benevolent sexism, in addition to hostile sexism, is a much greater predictor of tolerance of sexual harassment than gender alone (Russell & Trigg, 2004). In the future, studies should include the use of benevolently sexist attitudes as a measure to determine the relationship between benevolent sexism and engaging in street harassment behaviors.

Results indicated that there was a small but significant relationship between men's reported tolerance for sexual harassment and men's reports of engaging in street harassment behaviors. This finding suggests that street harassment is indeed linked to sexual harassment, as individuals who are more accepting of instances of sexual harassment appear to be more prone to engage in street harassing behaviors themselves. However, the small correlation also suggests that key differences may exist between the two concepts, which should be further explored in future research. Nonetheless, this finding makes a valuable contribution to the literature on street harassment by confirming its association with attitudes toward sexual harassment, which had previously been noted (Fairchild & Rudman, 2008; Kearl, 2014; Wesselmann & Kelly, 2010), but had yet to be empirically confirmed.

Street harassment has qualities that could be conceptualized as sexual harassment, such as being gender-based, but street harassment is treated very differently from a legal and societal standpoint. There are laws in place meant to protect employees and students from sexual harassment, but there are few, if any, laws that protect against street harassment (Fileborn & Vera-Gray, 2017). In addition, due to

its often short-term and public nature, it can be difficult to confront or report the harasser, so most street harassment continues unaddressed. Given the negative effects street harassment has on women (Fairchild & Rudman, 2008), and the results of this study that demonstrate its relationship to sexual harassment (i.e., significant relationship between men's reported tolerance for sexual harassment and men's reports of engaging in street harassment behaviors), street harassment should be considered a serious issue that needs to be better addressed both publicly and legally. More awareness and education for men regarding the ways that women view and are affected by street harassment (e.g., bringing awareness to the ways that women are made to feel unsafe by street harassment) is necessary. For example, men could be made aware that even if they believe they are communicating affection or engaging in the behavior simply to get a positive reaction, the behavior could still be perceived as threatening and anxiety-producing for the woman. Such interventions could potentially reduce how often women are street harassed and, in turn, dampen the negative effects it has on women. In addition, the implications of the gender differences in perceptions of and motivations for this behavior go beyond the scope of street harassment. Men and women often view behaviors such as flirting, domestic violence, and even sexual assault very differently (Henningsen, 2004; Shotland & Craig, 1988). Given that women are disproportionately impacted by the negative effects of these behaviors, more education for men about women's feelings and experiences related to these interactions could significantly reduce miscommunication, confusion, fear, and violence.

Limitations and Future Directions

Like all studies, this project is not without limitations. First, given the way power and control attempts were conceptualized, it could be argued that all communication is a control attempt or display of power because it is designed to elicit a response or behavior change (Duffy et al., 2015). For example, when we say hello to someone, we typically want the person to say hello back. However, there are many types of communication that are not persuasive or controlling in nature, such as informing or entertaining. Even with this broad conceptualization of control, the finding that most men are expecting a particular response when they street harass women is important to further understanding this phenomenon. Future studies could benefit by taking into account other conceptualizations of power and employing alternative means of assessing how much power a participant feels they have, perhaps by using field observation or lab experiments to further understand various aspects of street harassment. Furthermore, despite the use of dyadic power theory in previous work on stranger interactions (e.g., Dunbar & Abra, 2010) and its potential utility in understanding street harassment, the tenets of the theory were largely unsupported, suggesting that other frameworks may be better for understanding power in the context of street harassment. For example, future studies might investigate street harassment through the lens of social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) and self-categorization theory (Turner et al., 1987) to better understand the gender and group identity motivations.

Such theories suggest that men street harass as a way to enhance the status of their group (i.e., other men) by putting down an outgroup member, such as a woman. Relatedly, this study did not take into account the group dynamics of street harassment. Studies have shown that men are more likely to street harass in a group than when they are alone (Wesselmann & Kelly, 2010); therefore, the motivations underlying such behavior may vary depending on whether the harasser is alone or in a group.

In addition, the scales used to assess the primary variables were created by and for Americans and may not accurately capture cultural differences. Future studies should use scales that can be applied to broader cultural contexts to produce more culturally inclusive results. It is also important to note that the power scale was significantly modified due to a lack of scales that measure power within a stranger context. It would be beneficial for scholars to develop scales that can accurately measure power in a multitude of contexts and relationship types. Finally, this study was limited to a college population and therefore may not be generalizable to other populations. The majority of undergraduate men reported that they were equal in power compared with women, which could be due to their age or education level and may not be representative of how the average man who street harasses feels about women. Future studies should aim to test the relationships detailed in this study in a more diverse sample. A sample that includes participants of all ages and education levels would help determine which types of people are more likely to street harass, experience street harassment, or have higher tolerance for sexual harassment.

Conclusion

Overall, this study contributed to research on street harassment by examining why men street harass women and the relationship between power and street harassment. The results revealed that college men who perceived themselves to have lower power than women were most likely to report engaging in street harassment behaviors. The majority of college men surveyed reported engaging in street harassment behaviors and that they generally expected a positive response from women. In addition, there were significant differences in how men and women viewed motivations for street harassment, with men reporting the motivations to be more positive such as to demonstrate affection or to have fun, while women reported a mixture of positive and negative motivations by men such as the attempt to control women's behavior. The present study is one of the first of its kind to explore men's perceptions of street harassment in comparison to women's and to test the long-held view that men street harass to exercise their societal power over women. Although the exact cause of street harassment as a phenomenon remains unknown, this study is a helpful start in understanding and, hopefully, eradicating a pervasive problem that affects thousands of men and women.

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